

Cabinet**17:38 to 19:15****Wednesday, 11 February 2026**

Present: Councillors Stonard (Leader), Hampton (Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment), Giles (Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services), Harper (Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects), Jones (Cabinet Member for Housing), Kidman (Cabinet Member for Culture and Wellbeing) and Padua (Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice).

Apologies: None

In attendance Councillor Galvin (Leader of the Green Group)

112. Adjournment

112.1 Due to a disruption the meeting was adjourned from 17:38 to 17:59 to allow for the room to be cleared.

113. Declarations of interest

113.1 Councillor Giles declared an other registerable interest in item 7: Motion 11B – Enhanced Paternity and Adoption Leave for Council – Referred by Council as he worked for UNISON but did not represent local government workers in Norfolk.

114. Public questions and petitions

114.1 There had been no public questions or petitions received.

115. Questions to cabinet members

115.1 The Leader announced that there had been one question received from Members of the Council to be put to Cabinet Members for which notice had been given in accordance with the provisions of Part 3 of the Council's Constitution.

115.2 The question is summarised as follows:

115.3 Councillor Stutely to the Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services on the Norwich Airport Surface Access Strategy.

- 115.4 Full details of the question and response were available on the Council's website prior to the meeting. A revised version is attached to these minutes at Appendix A and includes a minute of any supplementary questions and responses.

116. Minutes

- 116.1 The minutes of the meeting held on 6 January 2026 were confirmed as a correct record. The minutes of the meeting held on 14 January 2026 would be taken to the next meeting.

117. Motion 11B – Enhanced Paternity and Adoption Leave for Council Employees – Referred by Council

- 117.1 The Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice presented the item. She considered that the Scrutiny Committee should consider the motion and the options available to the Council, including communicating with the Trade Unions, before it returned to Cabinet.

- 117.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

"I hope that this motion can be taken forward by cabinet and not stalled further, as council had indicated its support and there are many staff and their families, not to mention newborn babies and mothers, who will benefit. Will you reassure me that you are putting their needs first?"

- 117.3 The Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice gave the following response:

"The UK is implementing major reforms in April 2026 under the Employment Rights Act 2025. These changes transform paternity and parental leave from "earned" rewards into immediate "day-one" rights law has finally made paternity leave a 'day-one' right for everyone.

By enhancing our local offer, we are doing three things:

Supporting Local Parents: Giving mums, dads and partners the real chance to bond and support their families without fearing the bills.

Retaining Talent: We want to be the best employer in the area. Flexible, fair leave keeps our best staff from moving elsewhere.

Fairness for All: It helps close the gender pay gap by making sure childcare isn't just 'women's work'.

We would like to reassure members that options set out before full council in January will be presented to Scrutiny Committee for further reflection and robustness, including engagement with relevant trade union bodies."

- 117.4 The Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice moved, and the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment seconded that the item be referred to the Scrutiny Committee for its views before it was considered by Cabinet.

- 117.5 **RESOLVED** to ask Scrutiny Committee to review the motion and that this is returned to Cabinet for a final decision.

118. The Council's 2026-2027 Budget and Medium Term Financial Strategy

- 118.1 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects presented the report using slides (which are available on the Council's [website](#)). The 2026-2027 financial year would be a year of major change and unlike previous financial years, the 2026-2027 budget would be the final full budget before Local Government Reorganisation. There was a high level of complexity which included the uncertainty around costs, system alignment as the new models were designed, alongside the work transition and major one-off costs. Decisions around strategic priorities would need to be taken. Demand for the Council's services continued to rise, with inflation remaining persistent. The budget looked at meeting current pressures against future priorities while protecting services.
- 118.2 The main budget areas for consideration were the general fund, Housing Revenue Account and capital expenditure. These were detailed in the agenda pack and the slides. She thanked the Scrutiny Committee for the work that it had conducted in scrutinising the budget and the budget setting process. The recommendations were noted and would be fed into future budget setting processes as appropriate.
- 118.3 She commended the budget to Cabinet that had been developed in the context of sustained financial pressure, ongoing demand for services and continued uncertainty around the costs of Local Government Reorganisation. The budget was balanced and responsible that protected core services, invested in the Council's priorities and priorities that residents had highlighted. Financial resilience was a key part of the budget and the budget included a £1million contingency for Local Government Reorganisation.
- 118.4 The Council was proposing a 2.99% increase in the Council's element of Council Tax. This was a proportionate increase that reflected the financial realities of the Council. A prudent minimum level of general fund reserves of £5.5million. She referred members to the section 25 assurance from the s151 Officer that the budget was robust, estimates were considered sound and that financial risk was appropriately managed.
- 118.5 The budget was supported by the Treasury Management Strategy to ensure that investments were managed prudently and sustainably. The budget aligned with the Council's corporate priorities as detailed in the Council's community-led plan "We are Norwich".
- 118.6 The Cabinet Member for Housing seconded the report. She highlighted that the Housing Revenue Account (HRA) was a significant part of the budget and the proposed budget underlined the Council's commitment in the housing stock and the challenges that the Council faced. As part of this the Council had considered the rent levels and were proposing an increase in rents of 4.8%. This enabled continued maintenance and improvement of the stock. A significant amount of work had already been done but more was planned which included a new capital works programme.

118.7 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“Scrutiny flagged that this is a relatively healthy budget with some headroom and the importance of making sure that this council continues to deliver through the turbulent times of Local Government Reorganisation and the huge changes ahead. The committee heard that a key issue is the costs coming our way, with at least £1m earmarked for the changes alone in this coming first year. Some councils in the same position are forecasting a £25m cost over three years. We clearly can’t afford this and need to keep track on this spending and its impacts. Will you commit to asking the government for extra support, especially if the changes start to impact the most vulnerable?”

118.8 The Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice gave the following response:

“The Council will continue to engage with the government through established channels on key funding matters.

Local Government Reorganisation represents one of the most significant changes to public service delivery in a generation. It offers opportunities to improve operational efficiency, with any resulting savings contributing to the investment required throughout the post reorganisation payback period.”

118.9 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects moved, and the Cabinet Member for Housing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

118.10 **RESOLVED** to:

- 1) Note the latest financial information, the budget strategy incorporated into the report and the budget proposals, which enable the Council to set a balanced budget for 2026-2027 and Medium-Term Financial Strategy for the period to 2030-2031.
- 2) Note the Section 25 report of the chief finance officer on the robustness of the budget estimates, the adequacy of reserves, and the key financial risks to the Council
- 3) Note that the Council Tax resolution for 2026-2027 prepared in accordance with sections 32-36 of the Local Government Finance Act 1992 as amended by the Localism Act 2011, will be calculated and presented to Council for approval on 24 February 2026, once Norfolk County Council and the Office of the Police and Crime Commissioner for Norfolk have agreed the precepts for 2026-2027.
- 4) Recommend to Council to approve:

General Fund

- i. The council’s net revenue budget requirement as £24,250,000 for the financial year 2026-2027 including the budget allocations to services shown in and the growth proposals set out in Section 2.

- ii. An increase to Norwich City Council's element of the council tax of 2.99%, meaning that the Band D council tax will be set at £315.26 (Section 2, paragraph 2.14) with the impact of the increase for all bands shown in Section 2, Appendix 2 (D).
- iii. The prudent minimum level of reserves for the council as £5,500,000 (Section 2, paragraph 2.29).
- iv. Delegation to the chief finance officer (S151 Officer) in consultation with the portfolio holder for Finance and Major Projects inclusion of any minor changes consequent on the final local government settlement or additional grant allocations.
- v. Delegate to the chief finance officer (S151 Officer) the approval of technical virements for general fund, housing revenue account and capital budgets, to make budget transfers where there is no underlying change in the budget intention.

Housing Revenue Account

- vi. The proposed Housing Revenue Account gross expenditure budget of £78,014,000 and gross income budgets of £80,392,000 for 2026-2027 (Section 3, paragraph 14).
- vii. A 4.8% increase in dwelling rents for 2026-2027, in accordance with the government's Rent Standard. This will result in an average weekly rent increase of £4.80 for Norwich social housing tenants (Section 3, paragraphs 15 to 22).
- viii. That garage rents increase by 4.8%, based on CPI in September 2025 plus 1% (Section 3, paragraph 20).
- ix. That the setting of tenants' service charges is delegated to the Executive Director of Communities and Housing in consultation with the portfolio holder for Housing after engagement with tenant representatives (Section 3, paragraph 21)
- x. The prudent minimum level of Housing Revenue Account reserves as £4,848,000 (Section 3, paragraph 38 and table 3.4).

Capital and Commercial Strategy

- xi. The proposed general fund capital programme 2026-2027 to 2030-2031 (2026-2027: £22,408,000; 5 years: £57,526,000) and its method of funding as set out in Section 4, table 4.2, table 4.4 and Appendix 4 (B).
- xii. The proposed HRA capital programme 2026-2027 to 2030-2031 (2026-2027: £67,483,000; 5 years: £260,576,000) and its method of funding as set out in Section 4, table 4.2, table 4.5 and Appendix 4 (B).
- xiii. The capital strategy, as required by CIPFA's Prudential Code.

- xiv. Delegating to Cabinet, approval to include in the capital programme, additional capital schemes funded wholly by grant where it meets the Council's aims.

Treasury Management Strategy

- xv. The borrowing strategy 2026-2027 through to 2030-2031 (Section 5, paragraphs 5.19 to 5.27).
- xvi. The capital and treasury prudential indicators and limits for 2026-2027 through to 2030-2031 contained within Section 5 including the Authorised Borrowing Limit for the council.
- xvii. The Minimum Revenue Provision (MRP) policy statement contained in Appendix 5 (Section 5)
- xviii. The (financial) Investment Strategy 2026-2027 including changes to counterparty limits.

Summary of key financial indicators

- xix. Indicators for 2026-2027 through to 2030-2031 as contained in section 5.

119. Corporate Performance Report 2025-2026 – Quarter Three

119.1 The Leader of the Council presented the report. The report covered 1 October to 31 December 2025. Overall performance remained steady with 68% of Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) were on or above target, 16% showed early warning signs, 16% had reached a level where intervention was required and 1 KPI was pending verification and would be reported in quarter four.

119.2 The areas requiring improvement included:

- Rent collection – there had been a 2% rise in performance in quarter two but Universal Credit delays continued to drive arrears. A new workload system was being introduced to improve efficiency
- Re-let times had increased to 51 days primarily due to a transition to a new fire safety door contractor, the issue had been resolved and was not expected to recur.
- Temporary accommodation demand mirrored national trends requiring ongoing intensive management and careful use of targeted funding.

119.3 Performance improvements had been seen in the following areas:

- Housing Benefit processing remained strong at 20.9 days to process new claims which met the 21-day target.
- The delivery of the Warm Homes: Local Grant was progressing well with 50 private-sector energy efficiency measures installed in quarter three and further large-scale delivery planned through to 2028

- Customer satisfaction had increased following successful recruitment and digital channel use increased as more customers accessed services online.

119.4 A detailed overview of all performance data was available in the Corporate Performance Dashboard on the Council's website.

119.5 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

"Average relet time of voids is persistently high due to some known factors, and we are not alone in this as an area. However, because improving this, even by a fraction a month, is something that can make so much difference and help us to house people, could the cabinet member outline exactly what she is doing to look at how we are improving the process by which we update stock and relet it, from key hand in, to new residents stepping over the mat?"

119.6 The Cabinet Member for Housing gave the following response:

"Turnaround times for empty homes remain a persistent challenge, and this is an issue faced widely across the housing sector. Our current performance is broadly consistent with what we have seen in previous years. We fully recognise the impact that delays can have on residents waiting for a home, and improving void turnaround times continues to be a priority. We are actively focused on delivering further progress to ensure homes are returned to use as efficiently as possible

To drive improvement, we have put in place a number of targeted and practical actions that strengthen the entire end-to-end process — from the moment keys are handed back, through works on the property, to letting the home to its new residents. These include:

- Boosting capacity at the earliest stage, through the appointment of an additional voids surveyor. This is already helping us speed up initial inspections and get works progressing sooner.
- Increasing our ability to manage major voids, by engaging two subcontractors to undertake larger and more complex jobs. This allows our in-house team to concentrate on minor works, improving throughput and reducing bottlenecks.
- Mobilising two major capital contractors to help address long-standing investment needs across our stock. As these improvements progress, we expect to see fewer homes requiring extensive works at re-let, helping us bring properties back into use more quickly.
- Reviewing the full voids and lettings process, strengthening hand-offs between teams, removing avoidable delays, and ensuring we are prioritising works in a way that maximises the flow of homes ready to let.

In addition, our tenancy visit programme is helping us identify households who may need support to maintain their home. By intervening earlier, we can prevent properties falling into more significant disrepair, which in turn improves both the condition of our homes and future re-let performance.

Even small improvements in turnaround times make a real difference to the number of families and individuals we can house each year. We are committed to sustaining the progress already made and continuing to reduce re-let times wherever possible.”

119.7 As Portfolio Holder the Cabinet Member for Housing monitored re-let times on a monthly basis, both formally through the housing performance dashboards and through briefings. Different areas were being explored including any small wins and what created different challenges at different times. Several properties that were handed back to the Council had been occupied for decades where upgrades had been declined at different times. More work was required to work with tenants to understand why upgrades were not taken. She was confident in the work that was being delivered.

119.8 The Leader of the Council moved, and the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

119.9 **RESOLVED** that progress on key performance indicators for quarter three of 2025-2026 had been reviewed.

120. 2025-2026 Quarter Three Budget Monitoring Report

120.1 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects presented the report. The Cabinet was asked to note the forecast underspend in the General Fund. There was forecast underspends in both the General Fund and Housing Revenue Account capital programmes. Reasons for these underspends were detailed in the report. Cabinet were asked to approve the addition of £119,000 to the 2025-2026 Capital programme that was fully funded through external grants.

120.2 The Cabinet Member for Housing commented on the underspends in the HRA Capital programme. Capital works programme often did not run year-end to year-end. The Council was brining on board new contractors to conduct capital works over a longer term.

120.3 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“Regarding resources, we are told there is a “necessity to fill some vacant posts with interim staff whilst a route to permanent recruitment is considered” on p182. What are the challenges Local Government Reorganisation poses to permanent recruitment and how are these challenges being mitigated?”

120.4 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects gave the following response:

“The ongoing Local Government Reorganisation (LGR) programme requires the Council to exercise caution in making permanent appointments while the Government considers the proposals for establishing a new unitary authority. As noted in the LGR documentation, there is a recognised “necessity to fill some vacant posts with interim staff whilst a route to permanent recruitment is

considered.” This reflects the uncertainty inherent in structural change across multiple authorities.

Until the Government confirms the future governance arrangements, the organisational structure of a potential unitary authority remains unclear. This creates uncertainty about future service delivery models, staffing levels, and role profiles. Recruiting permanently into roles that may be redesigned, merged, or relocated carries significant risk both for the organisation and prospective candidates.

The measures to mitigate these risks include:

Filling essential posts with interim or agency staff to ensure continued service delivery while allowing flexibility to adjust once Government decisions are confirmed. This approach avoids long-term financial commitments while protecting statutory and operational functions.

Offering fixed-term contracts aligned to LGR milestones can attract a broader applicant pool than interim roles. It provides clarity to candidates while preserving organisational flexibility until future structures are agreed.

Providing transparent information about the LGR timeline, potential structural changes and reassurances regarding organisational commitment to supporting staff, helps mitigate concerns and maintain confidence.

Implementing internal support measures such as wellbeing interventions, career conversations, and temporary role enhancements can help retain current staff during the period of uncertainty.

Close co-ordination with the LGR programme board and HR leads from partner councils ensures recruitment decisions align with emerging service models and reduces the risk of creating unnecessary posts.”

120.5 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects moved, and the Cabinet Member for Culture and Wellbeing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

120.6 **RESOLVED** to:

- 1) Note the forecast **£84,522 underspend** on the General Fund revenue account and the **£207,764 overspend** on the Housing Revenue Account (HRA).
- 2) Note the forecast **£12,895,652 underspend** against the General Fund and the **£6,927,195 underspend** against the HRA capital programmes
- 3) Note the current position of the General Fund and HRA earmarked reserves as set out in Appendix 1
- 4) Approves the addition of £119,000 to the 2025-2026 General Fund capital programmes, funded wholly by external or ringfenced resources as set out in section 4.

121. Corporate Risk Register 2025-2026 – Quarter Three

121.1 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects presented the report. The report detailed the Council's Corporate Risk Register for quarter three of 2025-2026. Cabinet was asked to note direction of travel. The position at the end of quarter two had been reported to Cabinet in November. The Council had updated its risk management strategy which had been presented to the Audit Committee and approved by Cabinet. This had been implemented for quarter three. The risk register therefore included a refreshed risk scoring and a risk appetite score for each risk. All risks had been reviewed and details were included in paragraph 3 of the report. There had been no significant change to the Council's risk profile and the environment in which the Council operated remained high risk including in relation to funding. Progress would continue to be reported to Cabinet.

121.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

"CORP38 is the Devolution and Local Government Reorganisation. Given the huge impacts, costs and risks, it is good this is included - but what exactly is this risk measuring, and how do financial pressures form part of corporate risks considered when calculating this metric?"

121.3 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects gave the following response:

"The new risk strategy was rolled out to risk owners during Q3 of the 2025/26 financial year.

The risk strategy includes a risk template to help risk owners better describe a risk and score it using an "If", "Then", "Resulting In" method.

CORP38 is measuring NCC's work to ensure a smooth transition into whatever new authority is established, ensuring, through the transition process, that statutory services continue to be delivered and that our communities receive a good standard of service, whilst balancing this with the work needed to ensure we contribute positively to the creation of the new Authority/ies. This means that the risk focuses on multiple areas around budgets, planning, resourcing, working in partnership across Norfolk, governance and communications and most importantly our staff.

Financial pressures will be considered when assessing our risk appetite in accordance with the new risk strategy, as well as in evaluating current risk levels. This risk will be reviewed regularly, and interventions will be made if the risk score is not deemed acceptable.

It is widely recognised that homelessness and rough sleeping are complex issues that cannot be addressed by the local authority in isolation. In Norwich, we are fortunate to have a wide range of organisations and charities working alongside us to support some of our most vulnerable residents.

Within the action plan that accompanies this strategy, delivery partners are identified alongside the NCC Housing team, setting out clear accountability for each action. The action plan will be reviewed, reported on and updated annually to

ensure it remains relevant and that accountability is maintained. As part of this process, relevant partners will be engaged to contribute to and support this work, in addition to ongoing 'business as usual' partnership and collaboration."

121.4 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects moved, and the Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

121.5 **RESOLVED** to note the identified risks and the direction of travel,

122. Homelessness and Rough Sleeping Strategy 2026-2031

122.1 The Cabinet Member for Housing presented the report. The Council had a duty to update its Homelessness Strategy. The updated Homelessness and Rough Sleeping Strategy had brought together a number of existing strategy to create comprehensive joined up approach and acknowledged that homelessness extended beyond rough sleeping. Increased private rented sector costs and a shortage of affordable housing had created new demand on the Council's services which drove homelessness. The Council was taking a new preventative approach which was aligned with the Government's approach. The strategy set out an overall vision and priorities with an action plan which guided work over the next five years by working with partners to deliver support to residents. The action plan would be reviewed and updated annually.

122.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

"Thank you for this updated strategy. Homelessness continues to be a huge and growing challenge, and thanks are due to all the teams who work to help in this area. Could you explain a bit more about how key delivery partnerships in the city, for example NGOs and providers, will be involved in ongoing monitoring and evaluation of the strategy?"

122.3 The Cabinet Member for Housing gave the following response:

"It is widely recognised that homelessness and rough sleeping are complex issues that cannot be addressed by the local authority in isolation. In Norwich, we are fortunate to have a wide range of organisations and charities working alongside us to support some of our most vulnerable residents.

Within the action plan that accompanies this strategy, delivery partners are identified alongside the NCC Housing team, setting out clear accountability for each action. The action plan will be reviewed, reported on and updated annually to ensure it remains relevant and that accountability is maintained. As part of this process, relevant partners will be engaged to contribute to and support this work, in addition to ongoing 'business as usual' partnership and collaboration."

122.4 The Cabinet Member commented that there had been involvement in the development of the strategy from people with lived experiences to ensure their voices had been heard. Partners across all areas had experience of working with residents with complex needs. The Council worked with partners through constructive forums both on an formal and informal basis.

122.5 The Cabinet Member for Housing moved, and the Cabinet Member for Culture and Wellbeing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

122.6 **RESOLVED** to approve and adopt the Homelessness and Rough Sleeping Strategy 2026-2031.

123. Revisions to the Home Options Policy

123.1 The Cabinet Member for Housing presented the report. The Policy had been considered by the Scrutiny Committee which had made a number of recommendations that were detailed in the report. The Home Options policy had last been updated in 2021 and required an update to legislation and ensured that the policy addressed housing needs. The amendments were limited in scope and included new guidance, legislation and a plan to end homelessness. She welcomed the debate from the Scrutiny Committee which had been helpful as portfolio holder. A recommendation from the Scrutiny Committee had not been accepted as it was a long-standing provision that silver band was not awarded where a situation had arisen due to tenants' own choice. Other options to seek alternative accommodation such as mutual exchange.

123.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

"Scrutiny Committee resolved to ask that Cabinet remove the section that sets out that silver band for no garden access will not be awarded for those children who were born when the current property was accepted. This was for reasons including that children should not be punished for their parents' decisions, and that as children grow up perhaps parents might realise that they need a garden when they did not foresee this. The Portfolio Holder has not accepted this because they say the applicant's housing circumstances have been 'created through their own decisions and choices' - although this is clearly not the children's decision. What actions will you take to make sure that this policy does not act to the detriment of children, keeping them stuck inside for their childhoods (for example, can we facilitate a better exchange process?)"

123.3 The Cabinet Member for Housing gave the following response:

"While I appreciate the concerns raised, it is important to recognise that many hundreds of thousands of families across the country successfully and happily raise children in flats. Living in a flat does not mean a child is "stuck inside"; families continue to have access to shared outdoor spaces, local parks, play areas, and wider community facilities.

In the specific circumstances being discussed, we are referring to households who made an active choice to move to a property without a garden. In cases where an applicant's current housing circumstances arise from their own decisions, it is reasonable that they would not receive additional priority through the Home Options scheme for that same issue. However, this does not mean that families are left without routes to move if their needs change.

Importantly, Home Options is only one of the mechanisms available. Mutual exchange remains one of the fastest and most effective ways for social housing

tenants to find a more suitable home. It is widely used and works extremely well in practice: in 2025 alone, 160 council tenant households were able to move through this process. We will continue to support tenants in making best use of these routes, and to promote mutual exchange as a flexible and responsive option for families whose needs evolve over time.”

123.4 The Cabinet Member for Housing moved, and the Cabinet Member for Culture and Wellbeing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

123.5 **RESOLVED** to agree the adoption of the updated Home Options policy.

124. Norwich Airport Surface Access Strategy

124.1 The Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services presented the report. The report detailed Norwich Airport Limited’s Surface Access Strategy which had been required by the adopted masterplan and the outline planning consent. The strategy included all land within the operational boundaries and detailed targets and measures for surface access for all current and future tenant businesses. Proposed measures within the strategy included improvements to onsite and offsite infrastructure. The strategy encouraged alternative methods of transport for staff and passengers. The report detailed responses to recommendations made by the Sustainable Development Panel, several of the recommendations were outside the scope of the strategy. The strategy was sufficient to meet the condition of the outline consent. It was acknowledged that the document could be more ambitious in future. The Cabinet would endorse the strategy subject to two conditions, which were that the airport undertook an Equalities Impact Assessment to be distributed to all partner authorities and that the annual monitoring report is reported annually to the Joint Airport Consultative Committee.

124.2 Councillor Padda left the meeting at this point.

124.3 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“How does the Norwich Airport Surface Access Strategy actively commit to reducing carbon emissions and private car dependency, rather than merely accommodating forecast growth in airport activity, including for example through the use of binding modal-shift targets for public transport, walking and cycling for both staff and passengers, and enforcement mechanisms that will apply if airport growth results in increased overall surface transport emissions?”

124.4 The Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services gave the following response:

“Endorsing the Surface Access Strategy will enable the Council to commit the airport and its tenant businesses to implement the broad range of measures that are set out within it. The targets for sustainable transport have increased significantly compared with those initially proposed, following officer concerns that targets for passengers and staff were not ambitious enough and there was greater scope for modal shift.

It now contains precise and ambitious commitments from the Airport, which can upon endorsement by the councils be used as a positive baseline position to move forward from, which is a much-improved position from where we are now.

Without the strategy if the existing mode share remains unchanged, an additional 2 tonnes of Carbon Dioxide Equivalent (CO₂e) emissions would be generated each day by growth at the Airport through additional staff and passenger trips.

If the targets set out within this ASAS are realised, it could potentially save 2.1 tonnes of CO₂e emissions meaning that the CO₂e emissions would be slightly lower than the 2022 base.

This represents a reduction in carbon emissions compared to the estimated CO₂e emissions in 2022. This would mean that the implementation would result in a decrease in CO₂e emissions as a result of Airport growth.

Monitoring will be key with the ASAS being monitored on an annual/regular basis. Targets may need to be revised depending on the growth of the airport, the current transport landscape and performance during the preceding year. This will allow more ambitious targets to be agreed as the airport continues to grow, allowing the ASAS to eliminate the transport-related impact of this growth."

124.5 The Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services moved, and the Cabinet Member for Culture and Wellbeing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

124.6 **RESOLVED** to endorse the Airport Surface Access Strategy, subject to the following conditions:

- 1) That the Airport produce an Equalities Impact Assessment, which is distributed to partner authorities.
- 2) That the Airport bring their Annual Monitoring Report to the Joint Norwich Airport Consultative Committee annually for discussion.

125. Greater Norwich Five Year Infrastructure Investment Plan

125.1 The Leader of the Council presented the report. The infrastructure investment plan had been prepared to provide a longer-term strategic context for infrastructure investment decisions while eliminating the need to approve individual projects at Cabinet meetings of all partner authorities more than once a year. The projects in the plan were considered a priority for delivery to assist in achieving economic growth targets in Greater Norwich Local Plan (GNLP) and the Greater Norwich City Deal. The plan had been considered by the Greater Norwich Growth Board and was being recommended for approval to each district council. The plan included the updated position on infrastructure delivery, revised Community Infrastructure Levy income forecasts and provided updates on projects accepted within previous plans and Annual Growth Programme. Cabinet were asked to note that the Annual Growth Programme contained projects at Woodrow Pilling Park and Yare Valley Walk UEA Boardwalk and that the subject to the approval of the Council's capital programme by Cabinet and subsequently Council and the proposed use of the

remaining £25.5million reduced-cost City Deal Borrowing which was set to expire at the end of March 2026.

125.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“In October the Council discussed seemingly behind closed doors options for utilising the remaining £25.5m of City Deal Borrowing by the end of March 2026 as the Treasury was unwilling to extend its deadline for drawing down the money. None of the three district councils have got projects on which to spend the money despite the end date being known about since 2014. As a result, the proposal is to agree a Key Decision to allow Norfolk County Council to utilise the remaining £18.5m of borrowing flexibly within their borrowing requirements. To date, the City Deal borrowing spent has gone on environmentally damaging improvements to the road network. Please will the leader detail exactly how he will ensure that the remaining monies will be spent on infrastructure projects which benefit the environment and the large number of city residents living in deprivation?”

125.3 The Leader of the Council gave the following response:

“The Greater Norwich Growth Board is a well-regarded partnership between the four local authorities in the Greater Norwich area. It isn’t something we’re legally required to have — the councils chose to work together so we can plan and deliver the infrastructure needed for growth in a coordinated, transparent way.

When we talk about “planned growth”, we’re referring to the Greater Norwich Local Plan, which was formally adopted in March 2024. All decisions about the Infrastructure Investment Fund and the Five-Year Infrastructure Investment Plan are based directly on what that Local Plan requires.

The borrowing we’re talking about here comes from the original City Deal agreement with Government. That deal offered reduced-cost borrowing, but only on the basis that the Greater Norwich authorities worked together to deliver the Joint Core Strategy — the previous version of today’s Local Plan — and the supporting infrastructure. Because of that, the borrowing is ring-fenced. It can only be used for specific types of infrastructure: education, green infrastructure, community facilities and transport. It cannot be used for anything else.

There are several types of borrowing within the City Deal. The £18.5 million discussed here relates to borrowing that hasn’t yet been taken up, often because major infrastructure projects have changed or been delayed over time.

It’s important to stress that this is borrowing, not funding — it must be repaid. All of the district councils were asked if they wished to take it on, and all declined. Norfolk County Council has therefore stepped in as the borrower.

Crucially, although the County Council could legally use this borrowing more widely, it has chosen to limit it to the same categories of infrastructure the Growth Board itself would have applied. So the principles and priorities remain the same.

A good example of how City Deal borrowing has been used in the past is the Broadland Northway. Although it’s a road scheme, it was essential to unlocking the

largest growth area in our region — enabling new homes, including affordable housing, new community facilities, employment land and supporting services. It also paved the way for Broadland Country Park, a significant new green space funded through the Growth Board, which simply wouldn't have happened otherwise.

This shows the “whole-place” approach the Growth Board takes: making sure that homes, jobs, transport, green spaces and community facilities all come forward together in a balanced and environmentally responsible way.”

125.4 The Leader of the Council moved, and the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

125.5 **RESOLVED** to approve the draft Five-Year Infrastructure Investment Plan 2026-2031 (see Appendix A) which included:

- The proposed 2026/27 Annual Growth Programme (AGP), noting that the AGP contains projects at Woodrow Pilling Park and Yare Valley Walk UEA Boardwalk and that the allocation of funding for these projects is subject to the approval of the Council's capital programme by Cabinet and subsequently Council in the associated budget papers.
- The proposed use of the remaining £25.5m reduced-cost City Deal Borrowing, which is set to expire at the end of March 2026.

112. Draft Affordable Housing Supplementary Planning Document (SPD)

112.1 The Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services presented the report. The draft Supplementary Planning Document (SPD) supported the application of Policy 5 of the Greater Norwich Local Plan (GNLP) which required 33% affordable housing and 28% affordable housing for the city centre. The delivery of affordable housing should be onsite unless exceptional circumstances justified off-site provision. The SPD detailed how the off-site provision would be calculated. The draft SPD retained control over how s106 funds were spent. The Council received £1.9million in s106 commuted funds which had enabled the delivery of 700 affordable homes, including Goldsmith Street, the Mile Cross depot site and Argyle Street.

112.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“Given the deepening affordability and climate emergency, it is disappointing that the draft Affordable Housing SPD continues to prioritise viability flexibility for developers over firm, non-negotiable delivery of genuinely affordable, low-carbon homes. Will Cabinet commit to strengthening the SPD so that social rent, zero-carbon standards, and long-term affordability are treated as core planning requirements rather than optional outcomes subject to negotiation?”

112.3 The Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services gave the following response:

“The SPD cannot set new policy and must accord with the Greater Norwich Local Plan and national policy. All development proposals should be fully policy compliant unless it can be demonstrated through a full viability assessment that this is not possible.

Whilst the role for viability assessment is primarily at the plan making stage, both the national Planning Policy Guidance and policy 5 of the GNLP include the provision for viability testing at the planning application stage to reflect case by case differences and differences over time. It is up to the applicant to demonstrate whether particular circumstances justify the need for a viability assessment.

Policy 2 of the GNLP seeks to ensure that development proposals have low levels of energy consumption. This is therefore not an issue that can be addressed through the Affordable Housing SPD as the Affordable Housing SPD only supplements policy 5 of the GNLP.

The Future Homes Standard which is due to come into effect later in the year is aimed at enhancing the energy performance of new homes.”

112.4 The Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services moved, and the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

112.5 **RESOLVED** to:

- 1) Recommend that Full Council agree to go out for consultation on the draft Supplementary Planning Document (SPD)
- 2) Delegate sign off of any minor amendments to the draft SPD prior to public consultation to the Head of Planning in consultation with the Portfolio Holder for Planning and Regulatory Services as appropriate.

113. Award of two HRA maintenance contracts

113.1 The Cabinet Member for Housing presented the report. The contracts for consideration were to support the management of the Council’s hosing stock, which were annual gas safety checks and electrical tests. Contracts were currently in place but were due to expire in March and therefore contracts were required from April 2026. The Council had reviewed the contracts to ensure that it continued to meet the Council’s and residents’ needs. The work would be linked to other activity such as damp and mould to work closely with contractors. The contractors had been identified through frameworks.

113.2 There were no questions from group leaders submitted in advance of the meeting.

113.3 The Cabinet Member for Housing moved, and the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

113.4 **RESOLVED:**

- 113.5 To approve the awards of the contract for Domestic & District Gas Servicing as contained in Exempt Appendix A, (Recommendation 1) and Domestic Electrical Inspections and Testing (Recommendation 2), under the Housing Revenue Account (HRA) maintenance programme at a total value of £12,750,000.00 following completion of the process as prescribed within the relevant frameworks:

Item	Action	Works Programme	Value
1	Award	New contract for Domestic & District Gas Servicing and Repairs to a single supplier, CONTRACTOR A, for the period 01 April 2026 for up to five years to 31 March 2031.	£11,000,000.00
2	Award	Domestic Electrical Inspections and Testing (EICRs) to a single supplier, CONTRACTOR A, for the period 01 April 2026 for up to five years to 31 March 2031.	£1,750,000.00

114. Exclusion of the Public

- 114.1 **RESOLVED** to exclude the press and public from the meeting during the consideration of the below items of the exempt report on the grounds that they contained exempt information as defined in the relevant paragraphs within Part 1 of Schedule 12A, as amended, of the Local Government Act 1972.

115. Disposal of Assets (Housing) (Para 3)

- 115.1 (An exempt minutes exists for this item).
- 115.2 The Cabinet Member for Housing moved, and the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.
- 115.3 **RESOLVED** that the following recommendations were accepted as detailed in the report.
- 115.4 (An exempt minute exists for this item).

CHAIR



Cabinet

11 February 2026

Questions to cabinet members

Question 1

Councillor Stutely to ask the cabinet member for planning and regulatory services the following question:

“The planning condition requiring a Surface Access Strategy set a minimum requirement but allowed scope for the Council to require a more ambitious and comprehensive approach to mitigation and sustainability, as is common practice at many other regional airports.

While officers will have advised on what would satisfy that condition, could the Cabinet Member confirm that Cabinet is content to limit the scope of the Strategy to soft surface-access measures, rather than requiring a more ambitious package of mitigation and local benefit?”

Councillor Giles, the cabinet member for planning and regulatory services' response:

“Planning condition 26 of application 21/0011901/O requires the airport to produce a surface access strategy covering how people access the airport along with the Masterplan endorsed by the Council in 2019. The requirements can only relate to the access strategy in a defined area and not the operation of the Airport as a whole.

Looking at the progress made, it is felt that the ASAS contains precise and ambitious commitments, which can be used as a positive baseline position to move forward from, which is a much-improved position from where we are now. Measures include a combination of onsite and off-site infrastructure and promotional measures. The ASAS includes measures for Norwich Airport Ltd staff and passengers and for the tenant businesses. The ASAS is ambitious with specific but achievable targets and measures. It is important that all measures are within scope. Requiring the airport to incorporate measures outside scope would be unreasonable.

This is a live document and after endorsement progress towards delivering mode share targets will be monitored through an officer group from Norwich, Broadland and Norfolk County Council. This is in addition to formally reviewing the strategy annually with targets being amended as appropriate with the agreement of all parties.”

Supplementary Question

By way of a supplementary question Councillor Stutely asked whether the Cabinet Member believed that the level of ambition within the Surface Access Strategy was proportionate to the growth, health and wellbeing and environmental interests when other regional airports had considered mode targets and other mitigation targets. In response the Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services said that the Strategy addressed the surface access to the airport. Other impacts of emissions and how to address these would be done through partnership work. There was provision within the Strategy for the target to become more ambitious over time. Other regional airports had been able to introduce things such as an offsetting fund as there were larger and had more funds. It was better to reduce carbon emissions at the source rather than to offset these. The Strategy addressed monitoring while recognising that this was complex when only considering surface access. Therefore a diverse mix of tools were being used to monitor progress including the completion of projects.